the anti-corruption bandwagon, he had set up an organization called Bharat Swabhimaan Andolan (Indian Self-respect Movement) with the backing of RSS affiliates. He was looking for his place at the high table. The UPA-II government, astonishingly, carried the banquet to him.

The attempt to placate Ramdev had actually begun weeks before the ill-fated airport visit. The yoga guru had declared he would go on an indefinite fast if the government didn't take steps to bring back black money stashed in illegal tax havens abroad. Worried about the black money issue catching national attention, finance ministry officials had begun secret negotiations with the yoga guru. A special plane was kept on standby to fly out to meet the baba in his ashram at short notice. Sibal had been told to cancel a scheduled foreign visit and lead a team to meet Ramdev. Mukherjee and the prime minister's office (PMO) were kept in the loop. And yet, no one will quite reveal who took the final decision to meet him at the airport, though the needle of suspicion points towards Mukherjee.

That morning, Mukherjee was scheduled to address the Editors' Guild of India at the India International Centre. His arrival was delayed because, we were told, his previous engagement had got extended. When he finally arrived close to noon, the gathering was already restive. Mukherjee was duly apologetic and promised to stay for lunch. He gave a brief speech and then prepared for a question-and-answer session. 'Ask me any question you want,' he said, sounding a little more relaxed. A few minutes later, his mood had changed. His assistant had whispered something in his ear and he now looked visibly agitated. 'Sorry, I have to leave, something urgent has come up,' he said. Forgoing the IIC's baked vegetables and ginger pudding, he hurried out. A few hours later, we realized the reason for the urgency. News channels had begun to flash the 'breaking news' on the Mukherjee–Ramdev meeting.

Sibal told me later that the ministers eventually went to the airport not to 'receive' or 'negotiate' with Ramdev but to serve him an externment order from the national capital. 'We wanted to make it clear to him that he could not hold his proposed fast and start an anti-government gathering under the